

As a PM, I began by deeply empathising with each user type: teens, parents, and creators to uncover not just what they experience, but why. This shaped a solution grounded in emotional needs, product gaps, and inclusive design.

1. Understanding the Problem

Mapping core users, their unmet needs, and how TikTok currently falls short.

User Type	Core Needs	Pain Points	TikTok Gaps
Teens (13–17)	- Autonomy - Respectful guidance	- Overly strict controls - No path to earn trust	- No tiered controls - No behavior-based progression
Parents/Guardians	- Safety - Clear, easy-to-use tools	- Blunt, confusing settings - Low visibility	- Lack of transparent usage insights - Limited customization
Creators	- Reach - Content clarity	- No feedback on content restrictions	- No creator-side content classification for Family Pairing - No visibility incentives
Diverse Family Contexts	- Flexibility - Accessibility	- Conflicting rules - Tech/language barriers	- No multi-guardian support - No localized settings

2. Proposed Solution: Introducing Family Trust Levels

***Goal:** Transform Family Pairing from a static control tool into a flexible, trust-building system that empowers teens, supports parents, and aligns creators.*

A. Core Feature Highlights

1. Trust Level Tiers (Behavior-Based Autonomy)

A flexible, progression-based system that replaces rigid restrictions with earned autonomy.

- Teens begin at a default Trust Level (e.g., Basic).
- Advancement depends on behavioral signals (e.g., safe content engagement, healthy usage).
- Parents receive opt-in prompts to review and approve transitions.
- Higher tiers unlock more access (e.g., expanded content, search), while repeated violations or unsafe behavior can result in stricter settings or a temporary downgrade in trust level.

2. Creator Badging System (Parent-Aligned Discovery)

An ecosystem-level feature enabling safe discovery and alignment.

- Creators can voluntarily badge their content as "Educational," "STEM," "Wellness," or "Family-Friendly."
- Parents select approved badge categories in Family Pairing settings.
- Badged creators are prioritized in teen feeds based on filters.

B. How It Solves Core Challenges

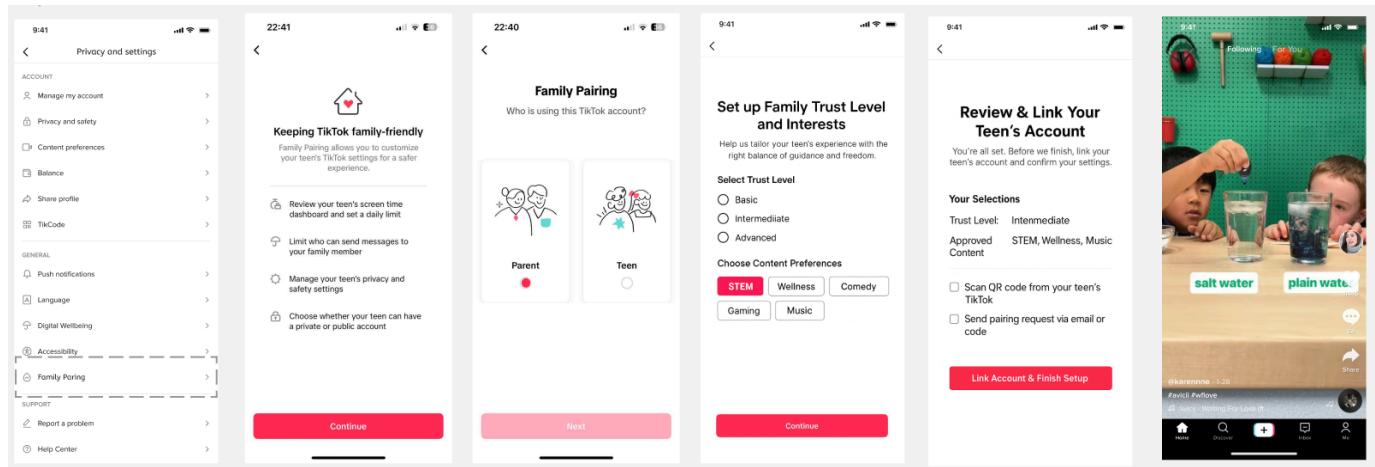
Challenge	How This Solution Helps
One-size-fits-all controls	Trust Levels adapt by age and behavior, replacing blunt restrictions.
No feedback/progression	Teens earn trust visibly; parents guide transitions via structured reviews.
Limited parental tools	Content exposure is refined by category selection, not generic filters.
No communication layer	Nudges and milestones prompt regular, guided discussions.
Content transparency gap	Badging enables aligned discovery and boosts trust in creators.

C. User Journey & Integration

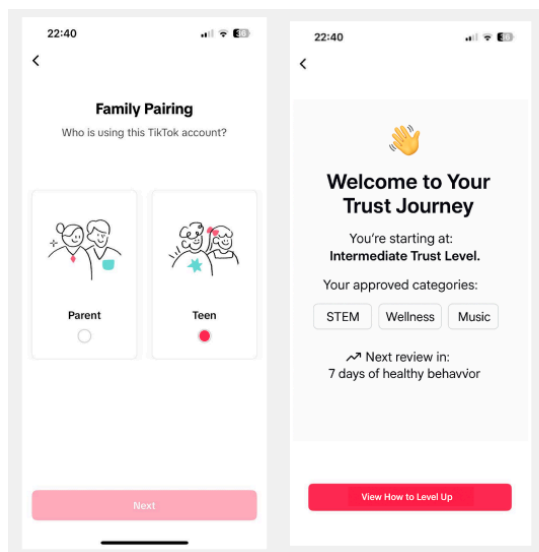
This feature integration reimagines TikTok's Family Pairing as a trust-building system, not just a control layer. Each user experiences a personalized, evolving journey:

- **Parents** initiate setup, selecting Trust Levels and content categories to match their teen's maturity and values.
- **Teens** are welcomed with clarity on expectations and can grow autonomy by maintaining positive behavior.
- **Creators** gain visibility in family-safe environments by tagging their content, enhancing trust and discovery.

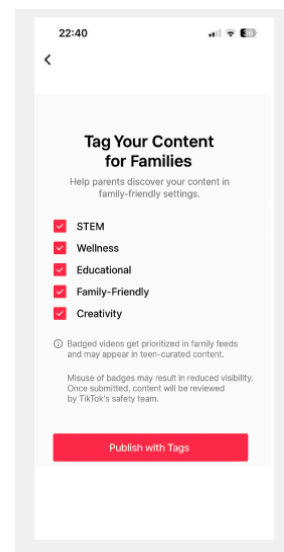
Parent:



Teen:



Creators:



3. Success Metrics

- 1. Adoption & Engagement (North Star Metric):** % of eligible families adopting Family Trust Levels, % of teens progressing between trust levels and retention rates for families using Family Pairing before and after rollout.
- 2. User Behavior & Sentiment:** Change in screen time behavior across Trust Levels, Teen opt-in requests for content access and Parent and teen satisfaction (via periodic in-app surveys).
- 3. Creator Participation:** Number of creators opting into badging, Engagement lift for badged content vs. non-badged and Parent-approved badge category distribution.
- 4. Safety & Conflict Reduction Signals:** Reduction in reported teen-parent conflicts related to content exposure (measured through help center data) and decreased attempts to disable or bypass Family Pairing features.

4. Trade-offs and Assumptions

Feasibility vs. Impact Matrix

Prioritization framework for initiatives

High Impact, High Feasibility

Trust Level Tiers

Foundation for launch with clear implementation path

High Impact, Low Feasibility

Creator Badging (Phase 2)

Dependent on ecosystem alignment

Low Impact, High Feasibility

Gamified Family Goals

Bonus feature to boost engagement

Low Impact, Low Feasibility

Community Education Portal

Alternative approach with resource requirements

Key Risks & Constraints

Potential implementation challenges

Badge vs. Hashtag Confusion

Lacks platform-level distinction, reducing trust value

Creator Resistance

Fear of algorithmic demotion or unclear incentives

Adoption Fatigue

Families overwhelmed by setup requirements

Privacy Concerns

Teens may view tracking as surveillance

Assumptions

Core beliefs underlying the strategy

Parental Engagement

Parents will participate in collaborative setup and review processes

Teen Motivation

Autonomy and trust-building will drive teen participation

Creator Incentives

Visibility benefits will outweigh badging effort

Edge Cases

Special scenarios requiring adaptation

Blended/Co-Parenting Households

Managing conflicting values and shared access

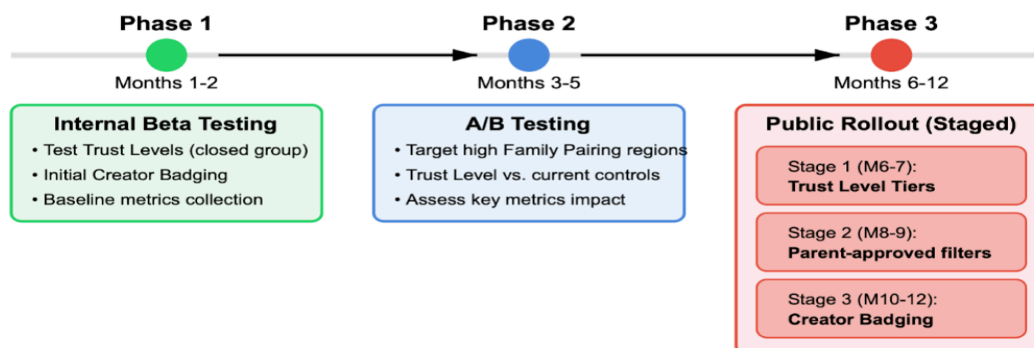
Low Digital Literacy

Simplified interfaces for less tech-savvy users

Cultural Variation

Regional adaptation for differing content norms

5. Rollout Plan



Appendix

6. Bonus or additional / back-up / alternative ideas

1. Gamified Family Goals

Introduce shared rewards for families based on consistent use of healthy digital behaviors (e.g., "7-day trust streak"). Could unlock small in-app bonuses or recognition badges.

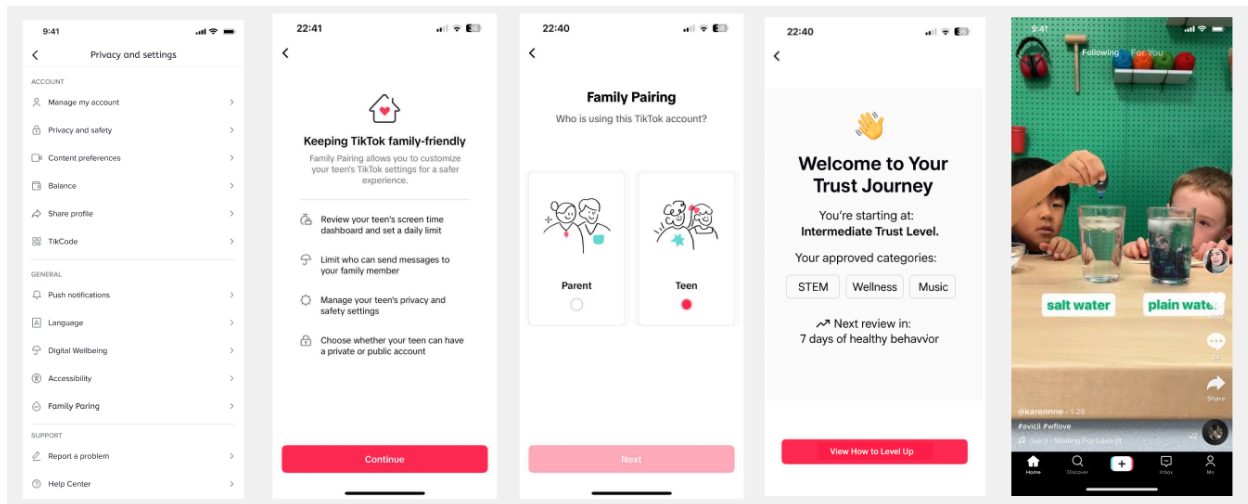
2. Teen Creator Leaderboard

A dynamic leaderboard that highlights top teen creators consistently producing safe, engaging, and positively badged content. This motivates teens to become role models while giving parents and younger viewers safer profiles to explore.

3. Family Insights Dashboard

Although not included as a core launch feature, this can be introduced later to provide high-level summaries of time spent, trust progression, and behavior milestones. Designed to build trust and clarity without intrusive surveillance. These alternatives can either complement the main features over time or serve as phase-two enhancements depending on adoption and feedback.

Detailed Teen Workflow:



Detailed Creator Workflow:

